Speaking at the Taj Excellence Business Awards function in 2003, Ratan mentioned how the hotel chain is unique for the ‘total experience’ it gives to its guests. Each employee gives every guest ‘affection’ from the time the person steps into the hotel. The guests enjoy this in abundance until they leave the hotel. When the chairman stands for value and not quarterly profits, then the company has an innate resilience, stronger than what attractive remuneration and benefits can buy, adds Kang.

‘Hurt But Not Knocked Down’

Ratan has indomitable spirit. When faced with this attack, he displayed unflinching courage—a quality that had influenced JRD to make him his successor—as he had done several times in the past.

During the three-day siege, Ratan was present at the site every morning, assisting the security forces, guests, employees and the general public in whichever way he could. Sunil Kudyadi, the Taj’s head of security, mentioned in an interview, ‘He [Ratan] was standing out there for three days. He had to be moved away to a safer distance. After the whole thing [the siege] was over, I met him at the back [of the hotel], when he was feeding stray dogs who were very distressed. He thanked me, and I was amazed at his determination and moral strength to stay through the event.’

He continued, ‘Ratan Tata’s personality radiates positiveness and people will put themselves in harm’s way for him.’ His insistence on remaining at the crisis site, ‘energized the entire team to do more’, and the employees’ ‘love for the hotel and the love and respect for him’ made the crucial difference.

Ratan was ‘there till the last guest was evacuated, he was a part of everything, and he was in the midst of everything’, comments Jagad. The determination he displayed to stand outside was also his way of demonstrating to the world that a few terrorists would not be able to break the resolve of the vibrant city of Mumbai.

Sounding singularly defiant and determined, he said in an official statement: ‘We cannot replace the lives that have been lost and we will never forget the terrifying events of last night, but we must stand together, shoulder to shoulder as citizens of India, and rebuild what has been destroyed. We must show that we cannot be disabled or destroyed, but that such heinous act will only make us stronger. It is important that we do not